it's the thought of you (that slightly scares me)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/41470341.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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by hopeisataste

Summary

adora and catra kiss at a party. if catra tries hard enough she can convince herself it's only just that.

or: catra falls in love with adora's laugh first and then the sound adora makes when catra kisses her second.

Notes

this is much more casual than i usually write. i have a time travel au wowza working on it for months thing going on and i wrote this in a couple days throughout summer break as a way to clear my head from the other one. then i sat on it for a month because i hated it. THEN i edited it while i had a killer cold. it's been on a journey. enjoy!

See the end of the work for more notes

*

It starts, like most of Glimmer's horrendously stress induced plans, with a party.

Which means it really starts at the end of exam season, Catra stumbling out of the library straight to her and Entrapta's shared apartment after a full day of work and one last test, tired and exhausted but finished. She falls on the bed the second she reaches their dorm, shuffles around on the covers as a way to try and ease her body from the strain that seems laced into her back after a week spent hunched over desks.

She half-heartedly turns her phone off do not disturb, already inevitably waiting for–

glimmer

so!!!

how did you find it?

catra

alright i guess

the stupid course is over so that's okay

glimmer

knew you’d say that

if you’re in any mood for celebrating or moving

like at all

Catra glances down at her messed up covers, thinks, dully, *oh*. Thinks that maybe Glimmer knows her better than she’d like to admit.

glimmer

i'm having a party friday

catra

okay?

glimmer

are you really gonna make me say it

okay

i want you there

come to the party

catra

did bow steal your phone lmao

glimmer

i’m serious

and everyone knows bow cant type without using a stupid emoticon

Catra doesn’t want to admit that she knows that, too. Thing is, somewhere in between the second lecture and the fifth Glimmer became a silent fixture in Catra’s weekly routine. And sometime in freshman year, Catra still rough around the edges, still missing home even though she knew it would probably be the last place she’d want to be, Catra, Glimmer and Bow became sort of friends.

The sort of exists in the fact that a part of Catra still doesn’t really know how friendship works. Even after knowing each other for a year, even after Bow got into the habit of silently bringing Catra coffee every time they caught each other at the library, even after all of that, there’s still a part of Catra that itches to ask *is this okay* ? Or worse, *am I too much?*

Knowing Bow and Glimmer marked the start of Catra’s actual experience of life and the end of childishly fearing what it means to know other people.

Their friendship was affirmed by the end of Catra’s first semester. It’s a memory that Catra returns to with mortification and a small swell of softness in her chest that she would never admit to.

It was Halloween. She was drunk.

The drunkenness was born from a desperate attempt to try and deal with the fact that her heart was still so sore from leaving home. She felt outside of herself for the first weeks of the semester, a sharp cold found bordering the edge of her ribs,

sprung out of a loneliness that festered in Catra's inability to confront it.

She had gone to some stupid event that she heard someone speaking about in the dorm. It was at a nightclub and Catra wishes she could remember literally anything about it but the night rings on how someone had touched her face before she could push their fingers away. She left the party because of it, a print of neon paint pressed across her jaw, the drag of her cheekbone. Her face was burning from touch, hands shaking and head swimming, and the worst thing was that it was her heart that hurt the most. So hurt, so bruised.

The night ended with Catra leaning over the toilet, preparing to throw up again. The sickness was partly born from anxiety and drink, partly from the last few weeks of hell, partly from the fact that Catra's just so *weak* . She's weak. She's weak when people touch her loving or not and she's cowardly enough to get sick over it and she shouldn't even be upset because she left home months ago and it's *still* awful, she left home months ago and she can't seem to find herself back from the act of leaving and–

"Do you," A shaky voice broke Catra's train of thought. She almost turned her head to look at the person, almost decided to try and be brave, be normal. But she was exhausted and it was night and her heart had finally tripped after sprinting through the last few months, trying to repair itself. "Do you need me to get you something? You, uh. You don't sound too great."

"Really?" Catra responded sarcastically, voice scratching around the odd darkness of the bathroom. "I don't sound too great."

The person huffed and shuffled into the room more. Catra dragged her sleeve over her mouth, tried to redeem herself just that little bit.

"And here I thought you were just confrontational sometimes."

The tone of the voice snapped Catra into harsh realisation. It was that stupid girl from her English class. The one with the bubbly personality and constant contributions. The one that had sat next to her that one time and leant her that stupid pen that Catra had to awkwardly ask for in the middle of the lecture after hyping herself up to ask from the start. What was her name? Glammer? Glitter? Glimmer?

Catra debated bashing her head up against the wall. But the bathrooms were gross and she was sitting on the floor miserably and couldn't find the energy to do it. Instead she just sort of pressed her head to the cubicle and loosely hoped to evaporate.

The situation was a confirmation for the question that Catra had those first couple months. The universe was against her. The universe was actually, wholly, against her.

But even with that, before Catra could protest, could put her defences up the way she always did, Glimmer stepped closer. Held the cubicle door open lightly, scared to not startle Catra.

"I know you're like, disinterested in making friends or something," Glimmer started, staring resolutely at the wall. Catra had finally mustered up the courage to look at her after hearing the tone of her voice. After understanding that. Well. Glimmer was sort of making an effort. "But you're ill and you're upset and I can't leave you here, okay? Bow would kill me. Also I think maybe I care a little bit. But also I just think Bow would kill me. So can you please, *please* just let me help you?"

Catra's breath hitched. She had treated Glimmer awfully these past couple weeks, fearful to give her heart out when it was still so sore and young and scared. But even against all of that, even against Catra not giving that stupid pen back in fear of conversation, Glimmer wanted to be there for her.

Catra let out a choked cough. It wasn't the sickness this time but instead a sort of response, her body not knowing what to do with this compassion, with this effort. Not born from Catra being

useful, or annoying, or needed, but instead born from Glimmer *caring*. The thought made something ugly swell in her throat, pressing to get out. But Catra wouldn't cry here. She wouldn't.

"Okay," Catra said, light. She scanned Glimmer's expression once. Watched as her features transformed from surprise to a fleeting softness she saw before. "Uh. What did you have in mind? I've never really been drunk before. If you, um, couldn't tell."

Catra was vaguely aware that she had never spoken this long to anybody without them having to force it out of her. But this didn't feel like forcing. Didn't feel like the only thing Catra really knew. If Catra was being naïve and hopeful and childish she might've even called it friendship. But it was hard for her to consider that as an option when she had no real understanding of it in the first place.

"Oh honey," Glimmer said, and Catra held the word in her hand, watched it expand and grow under the smile Glimmer gave her. "Trust me when I say I have. Let me help you up. I've got every remedy you can think of."

"Please don't give me one of those awful drinks with the raw egg in," Catra said, because she was still a bit drunk and couldn't bite down on the words before she said them.

"Contrary to what you might think," Glimmer pulled her up, took her hand. Smiled that smile that was a bit blinding against the vague lighting of a communal dorm bathroom at three a.m. "I'm not evil."

And so started the friendship that taught Catra what friendship was.

She owes Glimmer everything.

Doesn't mean she wants to go party after a bout of some of the hardest exams she's ever taken, though.

Still, Glimmer's Glimmer. And she's going to ask and Catra can't really ever say no to her when she gets super excited about

something. And if she says no then Glimmer will get Bow involved and then Catra *really* won't know what to do. Bow and his never ending kindness to Catra is fatal. If Bow asked her to buy him a puppy she probably would. So long as he asked while smiling and did that horribly nice thing where runs his hands through Catra's hair in greeting.

glimmer

i can see you have your read receipts on you dope

so?

catra

okay

i'll go

glimmer (source of all my suffering)

:D :D !!!!

okay that was bow

catra

i knew you guys were plotting

glimmer (source of all my suffering)

only cause we love you

catra

ew

love you too :/

glimmer (source of all my suffering)

you sap :’)

catra

bow?

glimmer (source of all my suffering)

no

you’re so cute sometimes it requires :’)

catra

blocking you rn

glimmer (source of all my suffering)

sure you are

party starts at 9

catra

got it

***

Because it’s the end of exams and everyone is falling out of the pattern of being stressed and tired, Glimmer's party moves from being a small casual affair to the sort of party that Catra hates.

She knows probably ten people here. And not in the nice way, not in the way where she can gravitate towards them and casually sit in their company. Instead everyone’s *moving* . There are a lot of people dancing in the middle of Glimmer’s living room, the speaker set up on a shelf nearby. Among them are the people that usually Catra would latch onto immediately, Glimmer and Bow themselves.

Catra debated interrupting them, pulling on Glimmer’s sleeve so Glimmer would move out of the folds of people and Catra could ask her to just sit for a while. The worst thing is that Catra knows Glimmer would do it in an instant. But just as she went to move, she stopped herself.

Glimmer and Bow were dancing. Not in their usual goofy best-friends way - not in the way that Catra sometimes participates in on wine-drunk nights with just them - but in a way that made Catra think *oh* . Think how she could’ve missed it. Missed this: Bow’s hands playing with Glimmer’s hair at the back of her neck, Glimmer’s hands sitting on Bow’s waist, running the hem of where his shirt rode up.

Simply missed the way that they looked at each other. Bow smiling, always smiling, but this time different. One of those muted sappy smiles that Catra catches herself making when Glimmer says something especially sweet, the honey of it melting on her tongue. And Glimmer looking at him softly, soft all over, moving her hand so it runs Bow's cheek and Catra looks away, then. It's too personal, something just for them.

It does mean, against the muted happiness of seeing her friends finally together, that Catra's still alone.

She decides to sit at the bottom of the stairs. Glimmer's stinking rich - something that Catra had to adjust to - so she has a really fancy two story apartment that her mom owns for when she's working in the city. Which is something rare and, if Catra's being generous, something that probably happens once a month. But it means that Glimmer's able to stay here if she keeps it clean (Catra vaguely hears something break a room away from her).

Catra met Glimmer's mom a few weeks into their friendship. She doesn't really know what to do with the fact that Glimmer's mom just accepted her. Catra was sitting at Glimmer's counter eating cereal and out of nowhere Glimmer casually introduced her and Glimmer's mom asked about classes and how Catra was doing. The second time they met she asked Catra about something she mentioned the first time they spoke. Like Glimmer's mom remembered. Like she wanted to hear about it.

Glimmer invited Catra over for Christmas after Catra mentioned that she doesn't really talk to her parents anymore. Catra cried when she asked. Glimmer didn't force her to elaborate. Catra told her why all on her own. Catra drowns in the beauty of that every time Glimmer catches her eye and smiles.

So Catra gets comfortable sitting at the bottom of the stairs, sipping something blue and bitter. She thinks there's vodka in it but she didn't really ask when Glimmer pushed it into her hands and then ran off to go deal with something.

It feels like she’s been at this party for days. It’s been less than an hour. Then,

“You got the weird blue drink too?”

“What?”

The girl smiles. She sits down next to Catra and Catra uses every ounce of her effort to not focus on how their thighs press together. Or how pretty the girl is. She’s all soft where Catra’s usually sharp, whole in all the places where Catra’s unstable. She just seems, so. Well. Confident.

Catra thinks she might notice that first - beyond the smile, because *Jesus* , that smile - since it’s something she herself lacks. The girl’s not scared to talk to a stranger and she’s not scared to smile even when that person looks unwelcoming. (Which Catra does. Like all the time.) And she’s not scared to push the drink out to Catra to show it to her.

“Glimmer, the girl hosting the party, she passed me this and I have no idea what it is.”

“She did the same to me,” Catra responds, looking down into the cup as an excuse to not meet the girl’s eyes. “I think it's vodka?”

“If it is, it'll hit me in a second,” The girl laughs. Catra watches as she fiddles with her bracelet. A nervous tick? Is it bad that Catra sort of wants to learn all the others? “Lightweight.”

“You don't, um,” Catra looks at the girl's body, muscular in all the places Catra is lithe. Feels her face grow hot but she’s already awfully committed to this. “You don’t look like a lightweight. Plus I don’t think Glimmer puts too much in. Less stupidly drunk people at her house the better.”

“I don't look like a lightweight?” The girl asks while smirking, and the sight makes Catra’s stomach drop. Catra looks away. Stares at the coat rack like it’s far more entertaining. “What makes me not look like a lightweight?”

Catra's cheeks go hot. She winces.

"Yeah just, forget I said that." The girl scans Catra's cheeks like she's surprised, catches the red and just sort of stares. Catra pathetically doesn't quite know what to do with that. "Please."

The girl blinks after a moment and smiles again, all sweet. The stairway is half dark from the noisy party going in the other room and Catra is hating the noise and the dark and everything the way she always does but would never admit to. Her skin feels sort of tight with change but then the girl's smile turns shy at Catra's embarrassment and Catra's just. Stops. Something in her stops and she smiles back. And the girl catches that smile the same way she seems to catch everything else Catra does. The girl looks like she just won something, making Catra smile like that.

"Okay," The girl says, doesn't push. It matters to Catra, more than she'd like to admit. "You know Glimmer?"

"Yeah," Is all Catra says, even though she wants to be childish and say *my best friend. She's my best friend.*

"And you are?" The girl asks, fiddles with her bracelet again. Catra wants to grab her wrist, then, hold it and run her fingers over the jut of bone. It's a horrible realisation.

"I'm Catra," Catra says, smiling a little awkwardly to distract from the fact that she's officially gone insane.

"Cute," The girl says, then flushes red.

Yeah. She's officially gone insane. She's going to wake up in her doom room and Entrapta will be in the corner doing some weird illegal Chemistry thing and she'll realise that the fumes have gone to her head and that she's dead or something. There's no way a pretty muscled blonde girl who smiles and darkness fucking recedes exists anywhere other than Catra's mind.

But it's that acceptance of dreaming, or death, or whatever Catra's irrational brain can latch onto, which causes her to softy ask,

“Cute?”

“Forget I said that?” The girl’s face has gone pink just to the tips of her ears. Catra wants to touch. It’s becoming incredibly apparent that that isn’t really a thought going away.

“No, no,” Catra says because she’s a masochist, because her heart speaks before her brain can catch the words. She turns to the girl fully then. A part of her - brave and new but strong in resilience, wants to see the girl flushed like this. Wants to think, after the girl dips her head in embarrassment, *I did that* . “You called me cute. I could find that insulting. What’s cute?”

“Your name it, um,” She says fast, then, looking up at the ceiling before catching Catra’s eyes. “Oh god this drink is really catching up to me. I called you cute because your name matches you pretty well. You know.”

“I don’t.” Catra says, and takes a sip of her drink. Maybe she likes teasing the girl like this. If she was being honest she’d accept the licks of desire she’s feeling, would acknowledge the want flicking its tail in her stomach.

“I just mean, God,” She tips her head back. Catra tries not to watch her throat. “You’re sorta like a cat sitting over here like this, away from everything, the noise. The name suits, Cat-ra.”

Catra pulls a face.

“See? The face matches too. Cute disgruntled cat.”

“Stop speaking, please,” Catra takes another sip of her drink, turns her head so the girl can't see her blushing. She thinks it’s useless. It’s reached her ears. She’s probably red down to her fucking toes because she’s stupid and the girl is so so pretty.

“You asked.” Is all the girl says.

“Okay then.” Catra decides. “No more stupid questions.”

“Be boring, sure.” The girl takes another sip of her drink. Scans Catra’s expression like she wants to catch the small smile curving on Catra’s face. She does, cheeks turning pink. “Whatever you want. No more stupid questions.”

“What’s your name?” Catra asks, rolls her eyes. “Unless you count that as a stupid question.”

“It’s Adora,” And because Adora’s casual and can laugh at awkward moments - confident in a way that Catra’s always been sharp at, always been jealous about - she says, “Not as cute as yours, I think.”

“Pretty, though,” Catra says before she can think. She tries the word on her tongue. “Adora. Well, Adora. I usually don’t talk to people this much.”

Adora looks down at Catra’s cup. “Is it the drink or the company?”

And because Catra’s feeling brave.

“You said you’re the lightweight, not me.” Catra shrugs, leans back.

Adora watches the movement, catching onto the way that Catra’s shirt rides up. Maybe she’s being a tease, but why not? She’s tired and Adora is pretty and nice and she hasn’t *pushed.* She lets Catra lead the conversation, lets Catra say what goes and what doesn’t and when Catra thinks about that she wants to hug Adora and kiss her senseless.

Adora’s gaze fall onto Catra’s stomach and then back to her face, eyes wide. “Are you saying I’m nice to talk to?”

Catra takes a sip of her drink, tries to not look at Adora.

“You’re nice to talk to, too.” Adora smiles. “This has been awkward and I will regret about, mhm, I don’t know, ninety percent of the

things I've said to you tomorrow but. As of right now? Yeah. You're nice to talk to."

And then Adora points out a photo of Catra, Glimmer and Bow that's on the wall and Catra blushes even harder after Adora accuses her of lying. Catra explains how she knows Glimmer and Adora watches her expression like she can tell that Catra cares about them a foolish amount, can catch it in Catra's voice or the way that she smiles when she talks about Bow. And Catra doesn't feel like she's being judged or made fun of or any of the other insecurities she feels when she speaks to new people. Adora makes her feel good.

Adora makes her feel really really good.

And that's like, a big deal, okay? To Catra that's a pretty huge fucking deal.

So Adora's everything Catra hates herself for liking. She's pretty and she's a girl and she makes Catra laugh, the throaty one that she rarely ever does because she always feels insecure about it. She makes Catra laugh like that again and again, until the night is really fading in and all Catra can think is, *I want to kiss her.*

After hours the party is more muted and the absence of a pulse of sound makes Catra think about how long they've been there. They've talked about practically everything, Adora never pushing Catra to say too much, or when she says too little never acting like that's an issue. Catra learns how Adora is an athlete (of fucking course, Catra thinks, watching the way the muscles on Adora's back move when she stands up to get drinks for the both of them) who transferred from another school a month ago for her program. She's a second year student like Catra. She likes the school but she doesn't know that many people.

"Hence why you're speaking to a stranger while sitting at the bottom of a staircase." Adora explains, fiddling with her bracelet again. Catra catches Adora's fingers, feels the pendant move under her thumb.

“Well, you’re not really a stranger anymore.” Catra responds.

Adora positively glows.

Catra tells Adora things, too, in a way that's unlike her. She talks about her course, Glimmer and Bow, the things she’s worried about and the things she’s happy about. Adora nods and listens and *listens* and asks all the right questions that never feel like too much.

So Catra might be a little bit in love. Just a little. It’s nothing.

Glimmer comes stumbling in later, Bow following just behind with a hand on Glimmer’s waist. Catra turns to look at them and notices, the thought of it causing her cheeks to burn, that her and Adora’s faces were close. That, as they’d been talking, Catra had moved closer. Or maybe Adora had. It doesn’t matter how it happened because the only thing that is ringing in Catra’s mind is that she *let it* happen. That she didn’t even notice something that would usually cause her to fidget, to move away.

Adora makes Catra feel comfortable.

Her cheeks burn.

“Oh! You met Adora!” Glimmer starts, smiling and letting her head fall back onto Bow’s shoulder. Bow’s doing that endearing thing where he’s trying to not let his fondness show on his face. Catra smiles. She lets Glimmer bumble half-drunk through this conversation while not thinking about how Adora is watching her instead of the pair. “Adora, hi! I was hoping you guys would meet! Catra usually never talks to strangers.”

“Really?” Adora says, sarcastic. “I would’ve never guessed.”

Catra, bold and brave and absolutely in love with how Adora is only watching her, rocks their shoulders. Says, quiet, *shut up.* She doesn’t try to defend it. Perhaps it’s an acceptance that, well. Adora is different.

“But I knew you guys would get along,” Glimmer speaks again, voice a bit too loud for the quiet hum of the hallway. “Catra’s super grumpy all the time but she only *acts* like that. Get her to stay long enough and she’ll start being horribly sappy. One time I fell asleep when she was over and she kissed by forehead goodbye-”

“Okay, whoa-” Bow starts, wrapping his arms around Glimmer like that will do anything to shut her up.

“Glimmer-” Catra hisses.

“No, I want to hear this.” Adora says, turns to Catra. Their faces are too close. “So Catra secretly gives people kisses on their foreheads?”

“Oh she gives kisses everywhere. It’s the absolute *worst*.” Glimmer responds. “Once we had an argument and instead of talking to me she just randomly held my hand. That was *so* mean of her. I was really angry because she had ruined my final project by accident. But *no* how do you stay angry at a sad looking Catra when she holds your hand? You can't. She has too much power.”

“Okay she’s seriously drank too much.” Catra says, face burning. She's trying not to look at Adora’s expression. The hand holding thing was one time and it was because she felt really bad. She had to spend thirty minutes working herself up to it. “And if anything–”

“Why don’t I get forehead kisses?” Bow asks, interrupting her. “If Catra’s just giving them out all the time I want one.”

“I’m not just giving them out all the time–”

“What are they? A finite resource?” Adora asks, laughing.

Catra tries to pinpoint when this conversation started to truly, awfully, unravel. She’s about to interrupt, steer it towards literally anything else, when Glimmer starts speaking again. Catra already anticipates the worst.

“Bow,” Glimmer starts, slurring slightly and turning around in Bow’s arms. Suddenly it feels too personal. “If I was any taller I’d kiss your forehead all the time. Sometimes I think I was made this short just ‘cause whoever made me knew that if I was tall I wouldn’t do anything else.”

“Oh my god,” Catra gapes. “Glimmer.”

“Oh,” Is all Bow says for a moment, and Catra watches as a flush spreads from his cheeks to his ears. His hand finds the small of Glimmer’s back. And Catra feels like she should be doing some kind of damage control, because Glimmer is drunk and she’s been waiting for Bow for years and this is not the type of thing that you can just throw around, can take back. Hearts are wet, fragile slippery things.

But then Catra realises she doesn't really need to worry.

“Really?” Bow asks, voice quiet.

“‘Course,” Glimmer responds, smiling softly. “If I was any more motivated I would buy stilts. But then I think I’d look pretty stupid.”

“Okay,” Is all Bow says, and then he smiles, and the truth of it makes Catra want to look away. “Yeah, okay. I’ll hold you to that.”

“Just so we’re clear,” Glimmer starts, finding the bottom of Bow’s shirt and fiddling with it. Catra’s still in shock. “Holding me to that does not mean I buy stilts but does mean that I can kiss you?”

Bow opens his mouth, cheeks still red, ready to respond, when Catra interrupts.

“Stop being gross.” She says, because she’s worried that the kiss that Glimmer’s complained about wanting for five years is going to come down to this moment. In the hallway of Glimmer’s apartment while Adora and Catra awkwardly sit there, not knowing what to say. “I love you both and I’m happy for you but *please* , this is too much.”

“I think it’s cute,” Adora responds.

“Do you disagree with me for fun?” Catra turns to her, bewildered.

“I thought we said no stupid questions?” Adora responds, smug.

They lightheartedly argue enough that neither of them notice when Bow and Glimmer leave. All Catra notices is that Adora is smirking and their bodies are close again, thighs pressed together.

The party is really dissipating now, people filtering out around them. It’s early morning and Catra has to work late tomorrow and she’s got that stupid essay to write but she’s still just. Happy. Content. Proud of herself, maybe, if she was being kind. Proud of herself for holding a conversation with a stranger and enjoying it against all her normal reservations.

Adora gets up to leave for a moment, saying she’s going to grab her jacket from the main room (Catra preemptively mourns the sight of Adora’s arms), when Catra’s phone rings.

Bow

This is from Glimmer :D

She turned on the audio to message thing?

Catra you better get with Adora or I swear to God the next time one of those dumb movies you like comes out I will deliberately look for spoilers to tell you before you’ve seen it she’s hot and you deserve someone great and shes hot and she literally wouldn’t stop staring at you date her okay bow can we oops things not turned off siri off siri off please

Catra

unfair that when she’s drunk she still picks up on everything

and like i'm not even going to try to respond to that

Bow

Fair enough

Although I will contribute that I think you do deserve someone pretty great

And Adora is great

So just.

Throwing that one out there

Catra

thanks man

and literally go take care of your girl

dont worry about me

Bow

Not worrying, I think we’re both just excited for you :)

You deserve this

And uh

Will do

When Adora comes back in Catra's still smiling at her phone. She's happy for her friends, really. Glimmer's been dancing around Bow since what feels like the beginning of time, since high-school, far before Catra even knew Glimmer at all. Glimmer's always been private about it too - Catra only found out after Bow started dating someone from his Chemistry class and Glimmer had found herself at Catra's door crying. And even then, even after tears and ushering Glimmer into the apartment with a hand on her back, it took a bottle of wine for Glimmer to really tell Catra.

So she's happy for them.

And maybe she's a little happy for herself, too. Adora is here and Catra likes her. Really likes her. (She should be so scared, but she's just *not* . And it's that truth that catches her out the most.)

"So Bow and Glimmer? How long has that been going on?" Adora sits, placing her coat over their knees like a sort of makeshift blanket.

"Forever, basically." Catra responds. "Although I don't think Glimmer was planning to do anything about it. Bow's that guy that always has someone interested in him? And Glimmer's never been the type to push."

"They already seem super comfortable with each other," Adora says.

"They grew up together," Catra smiles, dips her head back. She can feel how Adora watches her neck. "I'm sort of a late addition. I've only been friends with them for a while."

"And yet you're still a sap," Adora responds, smiling hard. She turns to mocking Catra after a moment. "I mean, secret forehead kisses? Holding hands? What else do you have up your sleeve?"

"Literally shut up," Catra shuts her eyes, cringing. She can't see the way Adora is looking at her. "I can't believe she said that. Unspoken rule that when I'm affectionate you never talk about it. I have a reputation to uphold."

“A reputation?” Adora asks, laughing. “ *You* have a reputation?”

“Yeah,” Catra sputters. “Just ‘cause I’m being nice to you doesn’t mean I’m like this with everyone.”

“So I’m different?”

Screw Adora and her ability to always be bold, daring. She says what she thinks and usually that would mean that Catra anticipates something to cut. Words are harsh, mismanaged things. But she trusts that Adora won’t say something mean. Perhaps she’s putting too much faith in someone she barely knows, but she can’t find the energy to be careful. Perhaps, Catra thinks hopefully, she’s finally growing out of the fear that paralysed her when she was younger.

So she says,

“Come on,” Rolling her eyes, instead of saying, *it’s obvious, isn’t it?*

Adora smiles, shakes her head in defeat. Her phone rings, then, and Catra realises that the house is mostly empty now. She guesses that the party has really ended. She sort of misses it already. Thinks that this night is something she’ll only be able to ever truly get just once, the memories too obscured and distant to really capture it as it was. To capture what it felt like, watching Adora laugh for the first time.

“Oh,” Adora says, and she sounds sort of disappointed. “I have to get back. I’ve got soccer practice.”

“This early?” Catra responds, and she tries not to match Adora’s disappointment. “You haven’t slept at all.”

“Well,” Adora looks down, fiddles with her bracelet. “I was planning to leave early but uh, you gave me a reason to stay. So.”

“Oh,” Is all Catra says.

"Yeah," Adora says, "Anyway, I should really go."

Adora pauses before she stands up, like she wants Catra to protest. But Catra *doesn't.* She's not brave like that. Even when Catra wants things – the way she wants Adora, childishly, wholly, hidden in the urge to press her face against Adora's neck and lay a kiss there – she doesn't fight for them. Catra has spent so long sprinting. And now, when she can step back, slow down, pause, she knows it's easier to do just that.

She lets Adora stand up, shuffle her coat on. It's quiet. Catra thinks that she could hold the silence in her arms and let it burrow there.

Then, before Catra's heart can catch up, tripping over itself in an effort to try and *live* , to do something with the pretty girl and her mess of feelings, Adora is at the door. She yells up the stairs a goodbye to Glimmer, getting only a mumbled response and a happy, far too energetic, *see you later!* from Bow. Catra loves how Bow always makes up for all the places where Glimmer is a bit stripped back. Not lacking, but open. Where she has space for someone else to fill.

(Catra wants a love like that. If she's being horribly honest.)

Adora opens Glimmer's door and Catra feels so awkward just standing here. She's never really been that good at conversation, never been that great at goodbyes. And although Adora is sort of an anomaly against most of Catra's social incapacities, goodbyes still remain hard. Especially when Catra can't figure out if this is the start of something or the end – if the sun coming up behind Adora's figure is the world saying that this is her last chance or her first.

"I guess this is bye," Adora says, shuffling her feet. Catra nods, suddenly mute. "Um. I'll see you around? Right?"

"Yeah," Catra says, quiet. She's gripping the door a bit too tight. Adora on the outside seems oblivious to her concern, though. She

hasn't moved. "Yeah, of course." Catra adds, even though she knows that *of course* finds a way to be baseless as much as it can be a promise.

"Okay then," Adora steps away finally, and she's so wide eyed that Catra almost – *completely* - wants to press her fingers to the soft of Adora's cheeks. Make her eyes crinkle into a smile instead. "This was, like, really fun. Alright, um, yeah. Bye."

And then Adora is stumbling her way down the path, away from Glimmer's apartment. And Catra's heart is breaking at the same time it seems to be saying that this is *right* in some unfair way. That this is easier – that as much as her heart is dull, and sharp, and everything human all at once, it's also safe like this. Protected.

Catra turns around, accepting that this is the uncomplicated fate. She knows that she might not be strong enough to give her heart to another person. She scans the room, the hallway – eyes dragging over where Adora sat, forcing herself not to pretend that she's still there – and catches onto some stray bottles and shot glasses. With Glimmer passed out upstairs she might as well try to be useful.

Before she can move to pick them up, something catches her wrist. She turns.

"Just tell me if it's a no, okay?" Adora says, wide eyed. Catra just squeaks, and before she can respond Adora is kissing her.

It's so soft. That's the first thing that Catra thinks. Adora kisses Catra so impossibly soft that Catra feels something in her chest crack with the force of that light pressure, with the way Adora holds Catra's face in her hands. Not pressing too hard. Never pressing too hard.

And before Catra can even adjust, can fall into the steady comfort of the way Adora runs her thumb across Catra's cheek, Adora

steps away. She looks confused, her chest rising far too much and too fast for a kiss that lasted barely anything.

"Oh my god," She says, and then she steps further back. "I'm so sorry. I should've asked. I was just walking away and I thought—did I read this wrong? I did, didn't I? I'm so stupid, as if someone as pretty as you would ever even be interested—"

And then Catra kisses her.

It takes a minute for her to work up the courage, but Adora, forever giving, spoke enough to give Catra the time. To make her finally decide that if a pretty girl is standing in front of her like this, heart out in a way that Catra can only admire, she has to kiss her. Shut her up, too, because if Adora said any more about how pretty Catra is then Catra would probably have done something even more embarrassing, like admitting all the horribly nice things she's thought in the course of the night.

Catra kisses her the same way Adora kissed her – soft all over, the comfort of it making Catra's hands shake against Adora's waist. She's scared. Of course she is. But there are moments for being brave. And Catra's spent the last year knowing herself differently, spent the last year learning how to wake up and say, *I deserve good things,* until she believes it. She falls into the small pockets of sound that Adora makes, catches them and holds them and lets them blossom in her hands, blessed.

There's a horrible moment, one that leaves Catra's mouth bruised, where Adora smiles against her mouth. She smiles into the kiss and it's like the whole room bursts into light, like they're dancing, holding each other, and Catra knows she won't get herself back from this.

She decides not to care, not to worry now. It's exhausting, trying to rationalise the pains your heart will face before you meet them. It'll always hurt. But this? Adora smiling against her lips, moving back to kiss the edge of Catra's mouth, like she wants to

memorise the shape of it. It doesn't. Not yet, anyway. And that's enough.

For Catra, who has fought and who has suffered and who has never been able to really put it all into words, that's enough.

Catra smiles too, in a way that she never would, an action confident where she's usually so uncertain. She smiles and her hands stop shaking as much and she presses a kiss to the side of Adora's mouth. And then slowly, like wading out into too cold water at the beach, she moves back.

She knows not to take too much. Knows that they maybe have to talk about this. She presses their foreheads together, anyway. Now that she's touched Adora she finally gets what Glimmer was talking about before, with the height and Bow. And then she gets scared about the fact that Glimmer said that with years' worth of a relationship and Catra's thinking those sort of treacherous things with only a night behind her.

"I don't usually do this," Catra says, voice raw.

"So I *am* different," Adora responds, grinning cheekily. Her voice is just as blown out.

Catra doesn't have a response. Maybe it's because she isn't brave enough to say that it's true, maybe it's because it's not exactly like that. Adora's different but also familiar. Welcoming, in a way that most things to Catra, with all of her anxiety and tough home life and self-sabotaging nature, doesn't find often. Instead, Catra responds by kissing her cheek.

"Don't get cocky," She says, smiling far too bright. The sun's rising behind them. She wonders if she's dreaming. Adora has the energy to look sheepish, her cheeks turning a deeper red. Then her face hardens, all of a sudden, hands falling onto Catra's hips.

"Is this okay?" Adora asks, and the words steal something out of Catra. "Tell me if this wasn't okay. I don't. I don't want to push. I should've asked earlier— I should've. I didn't, because I was

feeling reckless and had been wanting to kiss you the entire night, but I should've. I want you to feel good about this."

Catra can't speak.

"I just. Yeah. It was stupid, before. *I* was stupid. That isn't to say I didn't like it." Adora smiles. "I just want you to feel comfortable. So is this okay?"

Catra feels something, small and skittish and scared, finally pause. Adora *asked* . Adora asked if this was okay and she's being so horribly kind to Catra's heart, like she knows it's a young tired thing. Adora treats her like she's more than just lips to chase. And no one has ever really made Catra feel like that. Has ever asked *are you okay with this?* Like she could change how things went.

Catra nearly cries. Instead she says, voice broken,

"I liked it, it's okay." She pauses, scans Adora's expression while wanting to make sure Adora can tell how sincere she is. "And I wanted it. Don't worry."

"Okay," Adora says, "Just wanted to make sure."

"Thank you," Catra responds, tilting her head in a smile she knows must seem horribly sappy. "For asking. Really."

"I should, um," Adora starts, "I should really get to soccer practice. My coach is probably gonna kill me. Not that this isn't great–"

Catra takes her hands away from behind Adora's head and steps back. She stops herself from reaching out to touch Adora's wrist.

"You should go then," Adora's raises her eyebrows. "Not to be the voice of reason. We'll talk about it. And I don't want you to be late."

"We'll talk about it," Adora agrees. "I'll see you around, okay?"

Catra nods, and this time the suggestion of seeing each other again doesn't feel like a half promise.

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Adora leaves soon after that. Not before she awkwardly leans in to press a soft kiss to Catra's cheek for goodbye, leaving Catra stunned at the door and not quite sure what to say. Catra only returns to her senses when Adora is at the bottom of Glimmer's road and Catra's standing in the open doorway, pressing her fingers to her lips in an almost blurry realisation that *that* happened.

Catra kissed somebody. Catra kissed somebody who was nice and pretty and made her laugh. Catra *kissed somebody.*

Glimmer's going to be so proud of her.

(Maybe Catra's a little bit proud of herself, too. But it didn't take that much courage. Not when someone as beautiful and nice as Adora looks at you like *that* .)

Catra cleans for a while, tries to shake off the blush that seems tattooed to her cheeks. She puts all the trash away and then stands in the center of the kitchen, trying to process it all. Bow finds her, paused.

"Oh," He says, looking sleepy with his messy hair. "You're awake?"

Catra doesn't say anything, barely hearing Bow over the memory of Adora's hands on her waist, of how she watched Catra the entire night. Bow carries on, more concerned.

"Did that bout of insomnia come back? I can make you some tea if you need it. Or you can stay upstairs with us. I mean, Glimmer's passed out and you know how she likes to latch in her sleep—"

“I kissed Adora,” Is all Catra says, voice small. “And I liked it. I really liked it.”

Bow smiles and steps closer to Catra. He puts a hand on her shoulder.

“That’s great,” He says, and then he smiles even wider. “I’m so happy for you. Adora’s great and I know I said it before but I’ll say it again: you deserve someone great, Catra. If a perfect person existed you’d be the one who deserved them most.”

“Bow,” Catra says, and she looks him in the eyes and feels like she’s stumbled across riches. “Shut up. Literally. Speak like that more and I might do something awful like start to cry.”

“’S true,” Bow pulls her close, walks her out of the kitchen. “And I already saw you cry enough when we watched the season finale of Killing Eve.”

“I thought we’d never mention that again.” Catra responds gruffly into Bow’s shoulder.

“Dude,” Bow pauses, grimaces slightly. “Glimmer has *videos*.”

And then Catra is sprinting out of his arms, up the stairs, shouting about where Glimmer’s phone is. She gets a whine in response, until she’s bursting through the door of Glimmer’s bedroom and Glimmer is already desperately trying to send the videos to Bow, fighting sleep and Catra’s body, swatting her weakly. It doesn’t do much. They end up falling against the bed, Bow falling with them, and they all just lie there, grinning and content and alive.

It’s a really, really good start to the day.

(Catra doesn’t find a way to delete the videos. Glimmer says she’s keeping them to play at Adora and Catra’s wedding. Catra throws a pillow in Glimmer’s face and then tries to hide her blush in Glimmer’s stupid floral smelling pink duvet.)

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And suddenly, just like that, Adora is *everywhere* .

Catra has a hard time adjusting to it. After the party she was convinced that maybe she had dreamt it all – no one as pretty and funny and comforting as Adora would ever be interested in someone like Catra. She went days like that, unsure if the buzz of want under her palms, the feeling of ghost hands lacing into her hair, was a product of just a severe imagination, a pathetic result of the fact that Catra was a little bit lonely.

And then she sees Adora.

The first time, Adora is running with the rest of what Catra thinks must be her soccer team. They're making their way across campus, jogging in a group. Adora's close to the front – not the captain, but important, Catra guesses. She's talking to some other girl, pretty intensely, it seems. Catra tries not to notice how her cheeks are flushed, a mirror of how she looked at the party.

She doesn't notice Catra. Catra's thankful about it. She probably looks a wreck; she's been at the library since early morning trying to cram for a test. Plus she had a late night with Entrapta yesterday and she's sure if Adora took once glance at her she'd see Catra's huge eye bags and messy hair and decide that maybe she was only pretty for one fitful, short night.

The second time Catra sees Adora it's a different story.

Catra meets Bow, Glimmer and Entrapta at the park after class. She's tired, of course she is, but she knows that it won't be too exhausting to just sit in the park with them. It's a nice day, after all, for late September. Cold sun over the grass. The park is busy when she arrives, but she finds Bow and Glimmer well enough. They're pretty hard to miss, doing all the gross couple stuff that Catra won't admit she wants too.

“Hi,” Catra says, lying down dramatically in the center of the blanket they’ve brought. “Why did no one warn me that Professor Weaver likes to speed through her course? I swear I got like, three words worth of notes.”

“Ask for Entrapta’s,” Glimmer responds from where her head is lying on Bow’s stomach. “That girl has notes for courses I’ve never even heard of before.”

“Maybe,” Catra says, shuffles up on her elbows. “She practically writes in code though. Hard to understand.”

“Yeah,” Bow says, Glimmer making an affirmative sound against his chest.

They sit like that for a while, talking about their respective days. The park has grown busier now that classes are fully over but Catra can only hear the change – she’s contently half asleep on the blanket, Bow and Glimmer speaking in slow quiet voices about a movie they want to see later. Catra’s happy, calm.

That is, of course, until their voices raise.

“Uh Catra,” Bow says, and Catra doesn’t open her eyes. “Catra, you should really–“

And then she hears it.

“Hey,” Adora says, and Catra sits up so abruptly that she must look insane. She tries to push back the hair from her eyes and ends up shaking it out. Adora watches her and then squeaks out, uncharacteristically nervous. “Uh, hey Catra.”

“Hi,” Catra forces out, and her voice sounds rough from sleep and this is so so embarrassing. She knows what she looks like. Her face always puffs up when she sleeps and couldn’t Bow have said literally anything a few moments before this?

Adora goes red at the sound of Catra’s voice. Catra’s sleepy mind doesn’t really catch it.

“I was just walking by and saw you guys,” Adora explains. “Now I realise that you all looked preoccupied, sleeping or whatever. I’ll go–”

“No!” Glimmer and Catra say at the same time, and then they catch each other’s eyes. Catra never wants to see Glimmer look so accusingly smug at her again.

“No,” Glimmer says, effectively shutting Catra up. (It’s probably a good thing. Catra thinks that she might not be able to say anything else rather a brief, short, embarrassing, *arms* , since Adora’s wearing a short sleeved shirt) .“Stay. We have plenty of space–” Glimmer points to the short area next to Catra and Catra thinks, bitterly, *traitor* . “--and we’ve been meaning to talk to you.”

“You have?” Adora says questioningly, glancing at Catra. Catra looks away.

“Yup,” Bow responds, “We heard you’re hosting a Halloween party? And you haven’t even invited us? I’m hurt, Adora.”

“It was just an idea, I haven’t invited anyone–“

“How could you?” Glimmer responds, falsely dramatic. “After we worked on that project together? I baked you cookies for your birthday!”

“It was your birthday?” Catra asks, small.

And suddenly Adora is only focused on her, ignoring Glimmer’s continued justifications.

“Yeah,” Adora responds, shy. “I didn’t do something big for it, or anything. Haven’t been here long enough.”

“We could’ve done something,” Catra says, before she can think. She scrambles to correct herself. “I mean us. As a group. Glimmer and Bow and me. You too, obviously. Us the collective.”

“Us the collective,” Adora repeats jokingly, and suddenly it seems her awkwardness has dissipated in the face of Catra’s embarrassment. “Okay. It was pretty uneventful. But if I’m hosting this Halloween party you guys are welcome to come.”

She’s only looking at Catra. Glimmer coughs.

“You guys the collective, obviously.” Adora glances at Catra and smiles.

“Costumes, too?” Glimmer asks, excited and Catra winces. “Please say costumes.”

“It’s Halloween isn’t it?” Adora responds. “’Course. I’m expecting the best. It would also be good if you guys help me decide who else to invite. I’ve got other friends, obviously, but.”

Then Glimmer turns on her phone, already opening the notes app to list people off. Adora’s smiling and so is Bow and Catra realises, slowly, that Adora feels like a part of their group. Maybe not only because of Catra’s interest. If anything the promise of having to talk has dissipated from concern, and it just feels like Adora is here casually, easily, like she didn’t kiss Catra senseless a week before. Like she was supposed to have been here the whole time, tucked between Catra and Glimmer, listening to all the things Glimmer has to say with patience and small joking commentary.

Bow catches Catra’s eyes over where Adora and Glimmer are huddled together. He smiles and Catra falls back against the blanket in defeat, because she knows what that smile means. It’s the same one Bow gave her for weeks at the library after giving her coffee.

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Before Catra can blink, Adora enters their group like her absence never even happened.

And the worst thing, the entirely embarrassing thing, is that Catra and she become sort of *friends* . It's not that they don't flirt – they dance around each other the same way they did that first night, shy smiles and glances and one time Catra catches Adora trying to eat cereal with a fork after Catra comes down from Glimmer's spare room, voice sleepy and calm, the same rasp that Catra is starting to realise Adora has sort of a Thing for.

They don't mention the kiss.

They're still the suggestion of it, the knowledge between them that yeah, they did that. And they'd probably like to do it again, judging by Adora's fork episode and the fact that during a drunk game of twister Catra's face goes far too red with Adora hanging over her, smiling that confident smile that has something swimming, besides the wine, in her gut.

(Glimmer's the one who suggested Twister. Catra knew what she was doing. Double Trouble knew too, pouring Catra another glass of wine before the game started, watching Catra watch Adora. They pressed the glass into Catra's hand, said, softly, *liquid luck* , before winking. Catra wondered how she got there.)

But even with the flirting and Catra's perpetually red face every time Adora does so much as breathe, she doesn't act on it.

Adora's comfortable, in the group. For Catra to turn to her and say, in that forever abrupt harsh way of hers, *I like you.* Or, *please stop working out with Bow in front of me. It's bad for my mental health, my stability of thought,* it would ruin what comfort Adora has. And she likes Adora as a friend just as great. Adora's funny and she makes Bow laugh like no one else and she's helpful, too. When Glimmer can't pick up Catra from her therapy appointments Adora does, and she doesn't even ask why Catra was there. She doesn't push even though now she's allowed to.

Catra still tells her, though. The second time Adora comes to get her, bundled up in the cutest way possible to ward off the cold, Catra spits it out.

“You’re probably wondering what’s wrong with me.”

“What?” Adora asks, shocked. Catra interrupted her in the middle of talking about soccer.

“The therapy,” Catra responds, watching her feet. She kicks a stone. “I mean come on, you’ve got me from here twice. You at least have to be curious.”

“I’m not,” Adora responds, “That’s your business. And there’s nothing wrong with you going.”

“Really?” Catra grunts, harshly sarcastic. “Therapy doesn’t exactly scream stable.”

“So what?” Adora says, bold. “You’re great as far as I can tell.” Catra smiles and then tries to hide it in her scarf. “And even if you weren’t it wouldn’t matter. Do you seriously think I’m the type to judge someone because of that?”

“No,” She admits. “I just. People usually aren’t that nice about it.”

“Well screw them,” Adora responds. “You should be proud. Takes courage to work for feeling and doing better, I think.”

“Oh,” Catra says. They walk in silence for a moment. Catra decides to take Adora’s words, the support of them, and says, “It’s my family. I, uh, didn’t grow up in the best home situation."

“Catra,” Adora says softly. She turns to Catra under an orange leafed tree, the blur of autumn catching up to them. “You don’t have to tell me–”

“I want to.” Catra says, honestly. She sets her shoulders. It never really gets easier. “My parents weren’t that great. They never

physically hit me, or anything. Just up here," Catra taps her head. "Messed me up a little, I think."

"Oh," Adora breathes. "Oh Catra, I'm sorry."

Catra continues to walk down the path. In her mind she can't decide to look at Adora or stare straight ahead, ignoring the drop in her gut she gets when Adora so much as smiles, or laughs, or looks at Catra like her company is enough. And if Catra were brave, if she believed in herself a little more than she does, she would look back. She'd stare at Adora the way she wants to, the way she did that first night when it didn't matter at all. But she can't now.

She can be brave with Adora in a different way, now. Brave in a way that means telling her things like this, means showing her the unplucked ripe fruit of her heart and saying *take it, take a bite, so long as it's sweet. So long as you want to.* What she and Adora have grown into has swallowed up whatever fearless young desire Catra had that first night. There's more to Adora now, to them.

Catra thinks that most of her internal promises to be kind to her heart, to not let it bleed, can be found in the moment she's careful with Adora's. Hearts are like china. They're something you can stare at in the pathway of someone's smile and think, *pretty pretty pretty,* while also knowing that their beauty is found in the way that they're handled carefully. A beauty found in the fact that when they chip there's a loss but an acceptance, too. A knowledge that that's what it means to live. To chip, to fall apart and take form again, a thousand different ways, in a thousand different moments like these.

And Catra's only just learnt how to be careful with her heart.

To have Adora's? The way that she wants? She'd crush it. Catra's never been all that good at being careful.

So Catra's trying just friendship. Maybe it's because she knows that a part of her, scared but present and full, wants Adora to

know the messier sides of her too. Wants Adora to love her besides.

"I'm not going to say it's okay because it isn't." Catra responds. "But I'm okay. Now, at least. With you and Bow and Glimmer and all the people I sometimes think I don't deserve. I'm working on it. Was tough, the first year of college. It was really tough. I think I'm still trying to work through that. My parents weren't too fond of me leaving, missed their emotional punching bag, I guess."

Adora makes a wounded sound.

"I'm good now, though. Really. I just, I don't know, wanted to tell you that? If you're going to be this close to all of us you might as well know. I don't always act nice because of it. I'm not saying it's an excuse, hold me accountable and all that. I'm just saying. Um, be patient."

"Why do you think you don't deserve us?" Adora asks, once Catra's slow drawl of honesty stops. Catra wasn't expecting her to pick up on that part.

"Because you're all great? And I'm just like. Here."

Adora stops in her tracks. " *What?"*

"Don't make me say it again."

"You're joking, right?" Adora says, serious. "Catra you're amazing. You seriously think that way about yourself?"

Catra doesn't say anything for a moment and then, after a heart thudding moment, she finally looks up at Adora. She was right, about it being a lot. Adora's looking at Catra like she believes in Catra, believes in her wonder or amazement or whatever other word Catra doesn't have faith in herself to live up to. But what Catra didn't consider, what Catra forgot to remember, was that Adora looking at her like this also hurts. Just that little bit. Like Catra's aware of the fact that if she let herself have Adora, the way she wants, the way she fears, this wouldn't be overwhelming.

She would've gotten used to Adora looking at her like she was special because Catra would be. Being with Adora would affirm all the mean little ways Catra's always craved to be wanted.

But the Adora she has now is looking at her like that. And Catra doesn't know what to do with the softness filling up the space between her ribs, full. So she says,

"It's easy to, I guess." Catra looks up into Adora's eyes. She's painted gold in the soft autumn light. "To think of myself like that."

Adora hums.

"Some things are worth working hard for," She says, and the words somehow fill Catra up even more. Adora looks away for a moment, scans the trees around them, like she's gathering courage from the world around her. "You're worth the effort."

Catra processes Adora's words, holds them nervously, runs over them with the tips of her fingers. She lets them fall apart and take form again, fickle under her insecurity. Then she takes them, tucks them far too close to her chest, trusting Adora already far too much. She decides that if someone as beautiful as Adora is saying these things she might as well try to believe beautiful things about herself too. She says,

"I know," She smiles. "What do you the therapy's for?"

Adora laughs, head dipping back, and there's a part of Catra that grows further under that sound. She thinks, boldly, a mirror of the first night, *I did that.* Then she thinks about the line of Adora's throat, the way Adora's cheeks are red from the cold, matched on the tip of her nose. She thinks about kissing the red off Adora's nose. Thoughts like those don't surprise her anymore.

When someone like Adora looks like that and talks like that it's hard to imagine any other response. Adora was made to be wanted. To be wanted by Catra, if Catra was feeling brave and bold and honest, even in her own head.

Catra rocks their shoulders together, pulls on Adora's wrist to get Adora to stop looking at her like that, like she's the center of everything.

"Thank you," She says honestly. Adora glows. Catra tries to get control of the situation, of her thudding heart. "Now, back to not being greasy. I can only handle it for so long."

"Mhm, of course," Adora adds. "Wouldn't want to ruin that reputation of yours."

And then they're back to talking about mundane things, or nothing at all, and Catra's sort of caught out by how *easy* that was. Adora's easy and comfortable and different and Catra's okay with just this. She can tell Adora all her mean harsh secrets and Adora will accept them the way she seems to accept everything else complicated with Catra.

Catra knows there's one thing she's not planning to say anytime soon. She knows their budding young friendship wouldn't be able to survive with it, with Catra saying *since you've gotten to know the tragic pathways of my life it's only fair that you know this, too. The tired rooms and cuts of my heart, the stretch of my skin under the sun, the red it blooms when you kiss it.* There is a part of Catra that is shouting, *know me, know me* in an awful sort of mantra that can never really be met against her fears, her reservations, the fact she doesn't know what to do with the love people give her.

So Adora enters their group and it's wonderful, the way she falls into its cracks like nothing. She finds home in them, the same way Catra did a year ago.

("It's a skill," Catra says one day to Glimmer, on the sofa. They've been making their way slowly through movies and gin and tonics. Her tongue is loose. "You can find all the lonely lesbians in the city and adopt them. You and Bow."

“It’s hard work,” Glimmer says, serious. “Being parents and all. But it’s worth that moment, when they ignore you for weeks while you just want your pen back.”

“Shut up,” Catra says, “I apologised.”

“Yeah, last week, a year late.” Glimmer responds, “Took you a minute.”

“Do you even remember what the pen looked like? What colour it was?”

“It’s about what it symbolises, Catra.” Glimmer nods her head, repeats, “What is symbolises.”

“Symbolise this,” Catra says, and then gives her the middle finger.)

***

For the millionth time in their friendship, Catra wonders how she got to this point. How she let Glimmer burrow her way so far into Catra’s stupid, desperate heart to allow her to do this.

“Stop moving,” Glimmer swats her shoulder. Bow’s leaning on the doorframe, dressed as Han Solo, looking far too giddy for a party that hasn’t even started yet. Catra would glare if Glimmer wasn’t hovering such a pointy object near her face. “Do you want it to look good or not?”

“I don’t want to wear it at all,” Catra says, “I think a pretty easy solution would be for you to just step away–“

“But you don’t have a costume!” Glimmer protests, pressing Catra farther into her seat. The bathroom lighting is doing no favours to Glimmer’s already ridiculous Leia outfit. “And it’s Adora’s party. If you show up dressed as yourself she’ll just be disappointed.

“Thanks,” Catra says, sarcastically. “Glad to know that the only thing I have going for me is a pair of cheap cat ears and you jabbing something into my skin.”

“I’m not jabbing,” Glimmer says as she steps back to survey her work. One of her buns is lower than the other. As an act of defiance, Catra doesn’t tell her. “It’s just makeup. It’s eyeliner not even on your eyes. You can handle it.”

“I look ridiculous,”

“You look cute,” Bow says from the door. He’s watching them with such a sweet smile on his face that to Catra it makes this all seem, momentarily, sort of worth it. Then he adds, “Plus didn’t you say Adora found you cute as a cat or whatever. She could be into it.”

“Don’t say it like that.” Catra responds, “And I told you that in confidence.”

“What, like she’s a furry?” Glimmer interrupts, wincing. “I don’t know Catra, that sort of–“

“No!” Both Catra and Bow say at once.

“Adora’s not a furry,” Catra presses her head against the wall. “Why would you think of that first?”

“I don’t know!” Glimmer raises her arms defensively. “Bow said she was ‘sort of into it’, which I’m gonna be honest here babe, does leave a little room for suggestion,”

“Okay, can we just stop talking about this.” Catra interrupts.

“Sure,” Bow says, because he’s always easy like that. “What I meant was that I think Adora would find Catra cute however.”

“Oh that’s for sure,” Glimmer responds, rolling her eyes. “Couple of days ago she would not shut up about you on the way to class.”

“What,”

“Don’t act all surprised,” Glimmer smiles. “You guys have kissed. You keep on acting like you haven’t made it incredibly obvious that you’re into each other.”

“We’re friends now,” Catra doesn’t look at Glimmer. “I don’t know. Doesn’t that change things?”

“You’ll work it out,” Bow says, glancing at Glimmer fixing her bun in the mirror. “Plus being friends is just as great.”

“Quick tip,” Glimmer turns to Bow. Catra loves watching them like this – they bounce off each other even better than before. It feels both exactly the same and completely different. “Don’t wait as long as we did.” Bow makes a face, “It was great, I know. But pining for you since high school? When I knew we could’ve been dating much earlier? Not that great.”

“I liked it,” Bow furrows his eyebrows. “I’d have a good time with you however.”

“But you like kissing me best, right?” Glimmer asks, questioning. Bow turns red. “See? Catra, I know you. Don’t wait for this. She wants you, trust me.”

“What did she, uh,” Catra starts, “What did she say about me?”

“I’d break her trust if I told you,” Glimmer responds, leaning against the sink to fix her lipstick.

“What?” Catra chokes out, “I was your friend first!”

“And now Adora’s the friend who cooks me dinner when I’m too tired,” Glimmer glances at Catra. She kisses her cheek. “Up your game, that’s all.”

“You know I can’t cook,” Catra says, and then sulks. “And this is really unfair.”

“If you want to know so badly,” Bow starts, “Why don’t you just ask Adora?”

“Good one,” Catra responds and then she looks in the mirror.

Glimmer has painted on large, black, entirely humiliating whiskers. The ears make it worse too – they’re far too fuzzy, soft against Catra’s usually sharp demeanor. The worst is that Glimmer was right; she doesn’t have to do much else costume wise. She came in a fully black outfit. She wasn’t going for sexy but she wasn’t *not* going for sexy, knowing it was Adora’s party. But with the ears and the eyeliner on her face she looks halfway between a high schooler trying to be hot and just a really lazy person. She can’t anxiously comb her hands through her hair because of the ears. She glares at Glimmer from the mirror.

“You look hot,” Glimmer says, pressed against Bow’s chest. “That is what you wanted, right? You’re wearing those leather pants you wear when we go clubbing and you’re trying to get the attention of like, every queer woman in a ten mile radius.”

Catra flushes red. “I’m not even going to try and entertain that comment,” Glimmer turns to Bow, knowing he’s honest. “Is it bad? Don’t try to soften the blow. Lay it on me.”

“It’s pretty,” He smiles, “Lazy too. At least you’re on brand. Obviously it doesn’t beat us,” He turns Glimmer around in a slow circle and Glimmer’s smiling all sappy and all Catra can think is*, god, they’re really in love, aren’t they?* “Han and Leia win, I’m sorry.”

“No you’re not,” Catra says, “You’ve been wanting to do that couples costume since you knew couple costumes existed.”

“I’ve been saving it for the right person!”

“Do you hear what you sound like?” Catra says, laughing. “Are you suddenly a *Christian* for Halloween?”

Glimmer barks out a short, sharp laugh the way she always does when she finds something truly funny, and Bow and Catra follow not long after that. They're still fighting giggles when they get into Bow's car. Catra's thankful for it, the distraction. If she was alone with her thoughts right now she would grow increasingly worried about how she looked, the stupid ears and the way they seem to shout *want me* to Adora in the most obvious way possible.

They get to Adora's on time. It doesn't look too busy – Halloween parties have a way of sort of multiplying in size as the night goes on and more people don't care about where they end up. Catra's thankful for the quiet, though. It helps calm the shake of her hands.

Someone opens the door who isn't Adora. She's pretty, is the first thing Catra thinks. She's pretty in a way that is impossible to compete with, is what Catra thinks cruelly second. She tries to silence thoughts like those, but Catra's insecurity has always been an irrational unstable thing.

"Hi," The girl says, ushering them in. Catra can't recognise her costume but it looks like a superhero. "You must be Adora's friends! I'm Mara, her roommate."

"It's nice to meet you," Glimmer says, "Adora's mentioned you, actually. You're the soccer captain, right?"

"Yeah," Mara responds. "Although I am concerned that with the way Adora's playing I will soon won't be."

"Really?" Catra asks, and then clamps her mouth shut. She doesn't want to come across as too interested.

"I can't even be upset about it," Mara says, "I graduate next year and Adora's *that* ridiculously good that it feels like an injustice that she isn't captain, you know?"

Catra, who has never participated in team sports ever, just responds, "Yeah, of course."

“And you are?” Mara asks, and Glimmer races through introducing the three of them. Catra decides to keep her mouth shut. She’s still, after everything, not that great with new people. She’s growing out of it, opening up more. But Mara’s intimidating in that way all pretty confident girls are. Mara brings them further into the apartment, asking if they want drinks. “How does Han Solo take his liquor?”

“Not at all,” Bow lifts his keys, “Designated driver.”

“Leia, on the other hand,” Glimmer starts, stepping forward. “Takes her vodka with soda. Coke, lemonade. I don’t care. It’s Halloween.”

“Plan is just to get drunk then?” Mara asks and she’s smiling and it’s so awfully pretty that Catra wonders how Adora feels living with someone who looks like this. She’s also, impossibly, far more self assured than Catra. She’s at ease. Catra’s been pulling on her sleeve for most of the conversation. And she hasn’t even said anything worth worrying over.

“Of course,” Glimmer responds, serious. Mara barks out a laugh, then tells them that she’ll go make their drinks.

There are a few people that Catra recognises from school scattered around the room, all in varying costumes. It’s still relatively calm; most are nursing their drinks rather than downing them and since Adora’s still waiting on people to arrive it hasn’t gotten into full swing. Catra likes the feeling so far, though.

Adora steps out from the kitchen, setting a few bowls of chips on the coffee table. She’s dressed as Thor because of course she is. The costume is doing favours to her arms, her everything, and Catra’s dizzy. Adora hasn’t noticed them yet, still talking to someone on the sofa. Mara comes back, then, carrying Glimmer’s drink and a soda for Catra that she didn’t ask for but appreciates. She needs to do something with her hands.

Adora stands up, probably to talk to Mara about something. Mara and Glimmer are still talking about something but when Adora comes over she interrupts.

"Han Solo," She points to Bow, laughing. She lists the rest of their costumes off next. "Leia, of course, and... a sexy cat?"

Catra turns the most horrific shade of red and Glimmer snorts. Adora's eyes are still so wide so Catra guesses, from under where she's hidden her face in her hands, that Adora's brain hasn't caught up to her mouth. It should be endearing (it is endearing, like everything else about her) but mostly it's just humiliating.

"I think," Bow starts, sympathetic to Adora but enjoying the red of Catra' cheeks far too much. Who knew Bow was the one who loved Catra's discomfort best. "She's supposed to be *just* a cat."

"Oh," Adora says, and then her eyes widen further in realisation. "Oh my god. Um. Never let me say anything. Ever again."

And then she's making an excuse and stepping away from the conversation and into the kitchen, and Glimmer is hiding laughter into her hand until both Adora and Mara are gone. Bow makes eye contact with Catra over Glimmer's head and his face is so self-satisfied that she slaps his shoulder. Glimmer turns to Catra, just as smug.

"What was that?" Glimmer says. She puts on her best impression of Catra, which means that she really just sounds like she has a whiny scratchy cold. "Oh Glimmer I look ridiculous! Oh Glimmer there's no way that Adora likes me! Oh Glimmer how could I ever deal–"

"I get it," Catra interrupts. "Can you cut it out?"

Thankfully, Glimmer does. More people arrive and then the party really starts to move into full swing, with a group dancing in the middle of the room and music that's a little bit too loud. Catra finds a wall to stand against once Bow and Glimmer start dancing.

Entrapta finds her like that, the way she always does. Catra's friendship with Entrapta is born from mostly from the fact that they live together, and Entrapta's seen Catra with the flu or worse, when she saw Adora the first time after the party. All Entrapta said, in that great abrupt way of hers was, *okay you're in love, let's move on, please. Do you think this group project is going to do itself?* Catra values Entrapta a lot – she can be difficult sometimes, and when Catra's hurting Entrapta doesn't always know what to say. But she's there. And Catra appreciates that silent help most.

"You're a cat," Entrapta says, "I didn't know you owned the ears."

"I don't," Catra responds, gruff. "It was Glimmer. Who are you?"

"I'm the version of myself that goes to parties," Entrapta adds, "Spooky?"

Catra laughs. She looks at Entrapta a bit longer, notices a difference.

"I can see where you tried to change your hair," It looks curlier at the ends, like Entrapta was trying to tie it up or do something new with it. "If you needed help you could've asked."

"It didn't go well anyway," Entrapta responds, "I was trying to curl it to make it look different. But then I found it uncomfortable. It kept on getting in my face."

"Okay," Catra says, "Next time if you need help let me know. I can pin it back for you."

"You don't like doing makeup or hair. That's why you cut yours all off at the start of the year."

"Yeah," Catra says, and the great thing about Entrapta is that she's even more abrupt than Catra. It means Catra has to be the one to say things like, "But I like you. So next time tell me, alright?"

“I won’t.” Entrapta says, “It was a failed experiment. The way I normally do my hair is trustworthy and very useful.”

“Okay then. Whatever you want,” Catra responds, sipping her drink.

The party passes in small conversations like that, about everything and nothing.

Catra speaks to the same few people – her group, some friends from her classes, a few strangers that Glimmer introduces her to. Catra’s having a good time, even in the conversations with people she doesn’t know that well, even when she feels like she has to bite down on her tongue after saying the wrong thing.

And then suddenly, Glimmer’s somehow got Catra dancing.

When their friendship first started Catra was afraid of looking like an idiot - too nervous to scare them away somehow, just by being herself – so Catra would push Glimmer away. She’d shake off whatever hand Glimmer had put on her wrist and make some excuse. And Glimmer would frown, would say that it would be good for Catra to loosen up a little. But Catra was abruptly aware of the fact that in the action of letting go she’d be letting someone in and that, that was dangerous. No one deserved to carry her heavy heart, her mess of personhood.

But now? Now she’s stopped caring. Glimmer can hold all of Catra’s messes the same way Catra can hold all of hers, discovered in dark raw mornings where Glimmer whispered her insecurities against Catra’s shoulder while watching a movie, where she told Catra all about how she hates the expectation her mother has, hates herself for caring so much about it anyway.

So Catra feels good about dancing with Glimmer this time round.

She hooks her hands into Glimmer’s and Glimmer absolutely lights up, dragging her onto the dance floor. Some fast songs are playing – nothing top 40, because of course Adora’s the type of person who has a niche but easily likeable music taste – and

Glimmer starts jumping with everyone else, the press of bodies surrounding them. Catra jumps too, happy and giddy and maybe just a little bit drunk after Trouble pressed a drink into her hand.

("You know," Double Trouble started, "It seems like the only time I ever see you these days is when you're pathetically staring at Adora."

Catra squinted. The thing is they were *right* – Catra had spent most of the party watching Adora in her annoying Thor costume with her annoying muscular arms and thinking all sorts of things she could never say out loud.

"Whatever," Catra responded, holding the shot glass in her hand. "Don't you have someone else to annoy?"

"Never," Double Trouble smirked, "The way you're cute little face scrunches up every time I remind you that you're smitten? Totally worth it."

"Okay, I get it. My pining is your entertainment, or whatever."

"Not just yours," Double Trouble now looked positively mischievous. "Adora, too. It's amazing that even though your eyes stay glued to her you never seem to catch when she's staring at you too."

"What,"

"Good choice on the costume," Trouble said, ignoring Catra's confusion. "I heard Adora having a meltdown over it with Bow in the bathroom. What did she say, again? I think-"

"Trouble-" Catra interjected.

"Ah, of course," He smiles, and starts impersonating Adora in a voice that's eerily alike. "Something about *the costume being too hot for me to stay focussed on like, literally anything* . Your girl is just as bad."

“She’s not my girl,” Catra says, even though she loves the fact that they’ve told her all this. What she finds more disconcerting is the fact that Double Trouble perfectly got the crack of Adora’s voice when she’s panicking. “And you’ve got to stop with the creepy impersonations. Is that all they teach you in drama school?”

“Among other things. They also teach us how to take our liquor,” Double Trouble responded, “Drink up.”)

Glimmer and Catra dance for a while, Bow joining in after a moment and pressing a small kiss just below Glimmer’s ear. Catra smiles but it sort of gets lost against the blinding happiness of Glimmer’s, the way she pulls Bow in to kiss him properly, smiling as she does it. They dance as a three, hands together and jumping and doing all sorts of things that make Catra feel like she’s actually alive.

And then, before she can even fucking adjust to the idea, Adora is dancing with her.

Bow and Glimmer are dancing on their own, all slow in dragging in a way that Catra thinks is born from the fact that the pace of the music has changed. The fact that everyone seems to be dancing like that, too. Everyone is still pressed close against each other in ridiculous costumes and even worse smudged makeup as the nights gone on and more drinks have passed hands.

So maybe it’s normal, for Adora to be dancing with her like this. Hand on Catra’s waist, slightly messing with the hem of her black shirt. Catra’s woozy in the best possible way that before she can do anything she falls against Adora’s chest, presses back in a way that speaks of far too much confidence that she doesn’t have.

“Is this okay?” Adora asks, because she’s awfully considerate like that.

“’Course,” Catra responds, feeling loose. She’s pocketed Trouble’s words somewhere far too close to her chest and just decided to

just go for it – if Adora finds her hot in this stupid costume and if Catra feels pretty, Glimmer's makeup giving her an ounce of assurance to just push her over the edge of being openly flirtatious, she might as well. "Missed you, before. You've been busy."

"Yeah," Adora says, hot against Catra's neck. The song is still so painfully slow, warm almost, the feeling of dragging notes and heat and a pulsing room pulling at Catra's want. "Wish I could've spoken to you earlier."

"You did," Catra responds, wanting to tease. Adora's doing it too, with how close she's speaking into Catra's space. "Sexy cat? Remember?"

Adora huffs against her neck. "Well I wasn't wrong. You look nice. Really nice."

"Yeah?" Catra responds, because she's half at a loss for words.

Adora turns her around then, and her hand doesn't leave Catra's waist, still playing with the hem of her shirt, still teasing pressing down into the soft of Catra's stomach. And there's an ache, somewhere hollow and dull in Catra's chest. Because this feels– this feels *different.* Adora and Catra have been physically close – a few nights ago Adora fell asleep pressed against Catra's side and although Glimmer teased Catra's expression for the rest of the week, teased the way she made sure to shake Adora awake slowly, hand pressing some hair away from her head – they're friends.

And Catra's good with that. She's actually only just started fucking adjusting to that. The way she wants Adora both ways, all ways, so long as it's never not at all.

But then Adora is pressing one hand to the small of Catra's back and another to just above her hip. And it feels like more than friends. The way that Adora is looking at her, searching, lips a sort of soft pink that can only be born from too many cold shots, can

only be born from running her tongue against her mouth the way she is now. It all feels like more than friends. Adora watches her, scans her expression once. Her hands are so warm – like everything about her, soft and whole and full, Adora is so warm.

She says, voice low in a way that goes straight to Catra's gut, a voice just for her. Just for them. The small space between their faces, their bodies, the way that with every drag of Adora's thumb against the small of Catra's waist every single rule, every fucking reservation that Catra made out of wanting to do the right thing, to stop herself from being weak for a moment, is lost. Adora says,

"Don't act like you don't know."

Catra tilts her head, trying to stop her hands from travelling too far into the threads of Adora's hair. "Know what?"

"That everyone's been watching you tonight," Adora responds simply, looking far too confident for such a big lie. Catra also thinks – and this maybe her stupid fickle hope speaking before she can bite down on the words – that Adora looks angry about it. Not angry, never angry. Not at Catra. The right word would be jealous. But they aren't together.

(In this moment Catra wants them to be. All the other moments too, of course. But this moment most. She wants to play pretend – press a kiss against Adora's throat in greeting, lick a slow hot line down Adora's neck at the same pace of the music as a way of saying stay. But if they were together, *if they were together* Catra wouldn't have to ask. And for some reason it's that, it's that idea that makes Catra's heart ache the hardest. The idea that someone would stay just because they wanted to.)

"No they haven't," Is all Catra responds with. She'd make some sort of defence but she doesn't have one. She's been watching Adora most the night, who cares about who else has been looking at her.

"They have," Adora says, simply. Her hands fall to both of Catra's hips. The music is so so slow and Adora's eyes are so so dark. Catra likes it, likes Adora watching her like this. "But you wanna know something?"

"What?" Catra asks, and suddenly her voice is too small. She's matching Adora in making this conversation feel like just theirs – everyone's still dancing around them, shouting over the music or sloshing drinks around far too comfortably. But Catra doesn't notice them. It's the same as that first night; against the sun of Adora, Catra doesn't notice them.

Adora tips her head back, breaking the eye contact that has been far too intense for Catra's rationality. Although it's attractive in a way that is pretty distracting, Catra notices that the movement is born less from discomfort and more from the fact that Adora looks embarrassed. But before Catra can start feeling embarrassed herself, already conjuring a thousand reasons for Adora's uneasiness, so many sounding like – *was I too much, was I too much, I'm too much, I ruin things* – Adora finally looks down again. Catches Catra's waist.

"I was jealous for about five seconds before I realised it doesn't matter," Is all she says, and Catra's stomach drops. Of course it wouldn't matter. Of course it wouldn't matter because they're not dating and they never even came close to dating. They kissed once and now their friends because Adora doesn't want her and why, *why* does Catra pretend that she's careful with her heart when she never is?

"Why's that?" Catra hates how her voice sounds. She sounds less disappointed and more just angry. At herself most, which is the worst type of anger because there's nowhere to really direct it. Unstoppable force meets immovable object. Most of Catra is impossible like that.

But then Adora looks her in the eyes, really in the eyes. Like she wants to memorise the way Catra looks right now as she says it. She catches the line of Catra's mouth, the way she smiles slight in

the middle of the dancefloor in her stupid cat costume. Somehow the ears have stayed on. Catra should feel self-conscious with the costume and the way Adora is focussed on her, but she doesn't.

Because even now, even with all of her confusion, all of her hard to direct anger, Adora makes her feel good.

"Because they don't know you the way I do," Adora replies, and suddenly all the watching makes sense. It's like the room stops for a moment, as Catra studies Adora's expression. She's dark eyed and her hands are rubbing a slow circle into Catra's hips that are driving Catra positively insane.

"Oh," Catra breathes. Adora continues, says the next part slowly, letting every word fall like pebbles in water, like they matter. Like she's been thinking about them for a long time, too, preparing them with care the way she does everything else. For words with so much meaning they fall with so much ease. So unlike Catra, who chokes over the things that matter, her confessions feeling less like catharsis and more like an admittance of defeat.

"Because I don't think they could want you as much as I do." Is all Adora says, simple and honest in a way far too pure for this dark messy night. She's watching Catra so so carefully, like she's afraid that she's saying the wrong thing. Catra's heart is a bird in her chest, batting against her soft ribs under Adora's hands, asking to be let out. (Like most parts of Catra – asking to be brave.)

"Adora," Catra says softly, after a moment. She's sure that Adora can't catch it – it was so quiet and although the music is warm and slow like honey under the pulse of the party she's still hard to hear. Under the racket of her heart, in her own mind, she's hard to hear.

Adora catches it the way she always does. Her eyes land on Catra's lips, then back up again. Like she watched Catra say her name rather than heard it. And that, that's the thing that tips Catra over the edge. That's the thing that makes Catra decide to do something about this – Adora already looking half fucked out

observing her, Adora still quietly smiling like pretending being courageous is okay to the accept that it sometimes isn't, Adora's hands on her waist, her hips, the small of her back, everywhere at once but never close enough.

It's all those things.

But Catra also thinks that the moment is just as much born from Adora walking her home from therapy, running the snow out of her hair on a rare snow day two weeks ago, careful careful careful, like she didn't want to press too hard. Adora giving her sleepy time tea while watching a movie, inviting Catra over, just them, to show Catra some dumb game she found for free on Nintendo. Adora smiling at Catra over dinner like some sort of private secret, Bow and Glimmer wedged between them in the booth. Feeding Catra little bites of her food when she didn't want them, asking what she thought, like Catra made fucking leftovers matter.

And most of all, Adora pushing that red cup in Catra's direction and being so casually fearless in a way that Catra will never get used to, cannot get used to, if it means she appreciates Adora any less. If it means she doesn't look at Adora and think *, you're everything. And somehow, against something so fucking intimidating, you make me want to be more.*

So Catra finally lets her fingers thread into Adora's hair the way she's wanted the entire time they've been dancing. She says, voice that same rasp that she knows Adora likes,

"Kiss me already." Adora's eyes widen. "You can't say things like that and not kiss me."

And so, Adora does.

This kiss is hotter than the first one, heavier maybe, judging by the way that Adora feels so much more certain about it. She kisses Carta deeply, hands moving to press Catra closer against her hips. And Catra falls into it the way she does everything with

Adora, licks into Adora's mouth, presses closer. Even Catra can find confidence in the fact that she knows what Adora likes – she's had dreams of the small sounds Adora made when they kissed for the first time, found them in every song she likes, every whistle of the earth in the early mornings, the silent creaking of a door when she's trying to sleep and think about literally anything else.

So Catra kisses Adora how she knows Adora likes – slow, deep, never too much or too little. There's a giddy childish pride found in the fact that Catra knows what Adora likes in the first place, is able to recognise it in the whine she makes there, as Catra kisses her neck, to the tightening of her hands on Catra's waist when Catra moves back. Catra's careful when she touches Adora too; there is a part of her that fears if she pressed too hard, danced her fingers against the freckles of Adora's skin too fast, let her messy heart spill over all over the floor of Adora's cramped apartment, Adora would stop wanting her.

It would confirm what Catra already knows about herself – that even at the best of times, even after she dismantles it again and again as a way of trying to make the pieces of thought not fit together, like a child clueless to how puzzle pieces work, she's too much. She ruins things.

As much as Catra has worked on herself, is working on herself, because healing a wound never really comes with no amount of bruises, thoughts like those are still present. And they're easy to believe. That's the worst thing – hating yourself is like slipping on a well-worn dress from nights you don't want to remember. There's simple undeniable comfort found in habit, but a suffocation in the fact that that's how you have to find it.

But Catra's not really thinking too much about that now. It's silent, mutable, if anything. Doesn't mean it's not there. Maybe that's the worst thing.

Adora pulls back after a short kiss. It seems all of reality floods back in; the music, the people shouting and laughing and doing all sorts of things Catra would usually find so overwhelming. The

ears are now slanted on her head. She only notices because Adora fixes them, pushes them back into position and says,

“Hi Catra,” She’s beaming, really beaming, soft pink lips wet from kissing.

“Hey Adora,” Catra responds, feeling almost shy. She tries not to let it show – confidence is sexy. She’s not wearing this stupid cat costume for nothing (Don’t tell Glimmer she said that.) Someone knocks into them, the music now fast paced. Adora glances behind her.

“Do you want to get out of here?”

“What? This is your party, remember?”

“No I mean,” Adora flushes red, fighting the words out. Catra loves how she switches between things, cocky to nervous, uncertain to pleased. It’s like Catra is slowly learning all the shades of Adora to memorise, knowing the pattern of how she’ll act before she does. A sort of game – How Bad Do I Have It For This Girl?. “Out of here, dancing. Want to kiss you without feeling like I’m on a capsizing boat with how many people are rocking into me.”

“Have you ever been on a capsizing boat?” Catra asks, partly because she’s curious and partly because she doesn’t have an answer to Adora’s question yet. They’ve made a bubble here, a moment. Catra always doubts whatever this is will be able to survive without that.

Adora steps out besides, answers Catra’s question while pulling her out of the folds of people by her wrist.

“Sailing camp in eighth grade,” Is what Adora responds with, because whatever Catra asks she always has an answer for, rarely hesitant. “Forgot to tell the instructor that I’d never been on a boat before and she just threw me out there.”

“How long did you last?”

They've made it to Adora's small cramped kitchen, vacated because Mara's got the speaker and is playing songs you *have* to dance to, according to Glimmer. Catra sits up on the counter, feeling antsy. If she stood right next to Adora her hands would travel far too fast, far too heavy, for the conversation.

"'Till I was really in the water? Ten minutes. Surprisingly good if you ask me, for a girl who's not really good at anything else bar kicking a ball around mindlessly."

"Don't say that," Catra says, brow furrowed.

"Is ten minutes really that bad? The instructor made it sound normal–"

"I'm talking about you saying you're only good at one thing," Catra tries her hardest to look Adora right in the eyes. "You're good at lots of things."

Adora stops fiddling with the drinks and looks over to Catra then. She looks sort of shocked, like that was the last thing she was expecting Catra to say. Maybe she's right – Catra and compliments are like oil and water. They always sound too scratchy, too insincere, too random and personal and unconvincing, coming out of her mouth.

"I'm really only good at soccer–" Adora protests. Catra can't have that. Sometimes she catches herself willfully being uncomfortable, or embarrassed, just for her friends. She wonders if that's what love is. Fulfilling sacrifice.

"No, you're not. You make me laugh, and you make Bow laugh. You take care of Glimmer when she's the person who hates being coddled more than anything."

Adora's still speechless for a moment. She walks away from the other side of the kitchen – a short distance that feels like ages as Catra watches her. She steps just in front of Catra, places a tentative hand on her thigh. It burns.

“You know Glimmer tried to warn me, that first day we met.” Catra raises her eyebrow. “About how sappy you were. Should’ve listened.”

“Please don’t remind me.” Catra drags a hand across her face, cringing.

“Still waiting for you to kiss my forehead goodbye,” Adora says wistfully, jokingly, but it makes Catra’s gut drop all the same.

“I’d never kiss you halfway like that,” Is what Catra says next, the words falling into the room around them and landing awkwardly. Adora steps just before her, in the vee of her legs. Suddenly Catra hates this, suddenly she’s wondering why she never went fucking mute, to save herself from pretty girls and their stupid power over her brain to mouth filter.

“Oh yeah?” Adora says, then she smirks. “Prove it.”

And then Catra’s falling forward, hands finding the back of Adora’s head, the soft of her hair, and they’re kissing.

It will never not feel new, not feel like the first time. And maybe Catra’s a bit afraid of that. But then Adora is gently cradling her face, pushing her head back so she can get a better angle, and Catra realises that being scared in a moment like this isn’t worth it. Sure, her feelings for Adora are big and bad and intimidating but they all boil down to one thing – to leave Adora unkissed would be torture. Not when Adora looks like that. Not when Catra sometimes thinks she was made for it.

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Miraculously, they make it out of the kitchen.

There's a shout from the main living room that makes Adora abruptly break apart from Catra. She's still sitting on the counter and Adora's hands are resting on the high of her thighs. She feels the press of them before she sees them, eyes opening to find Adora squeezing her thighs once before stepping back.

Catra dully registers the lack of distance, decides that sitting further back into the counter might be a good idea since in the process of kissing Adora she moved closer and closer to the edge, like her eventual goal was for Adora to pick her up.

(Don't think about it. Don't think about it. Don't think about it.)

"I should," Adora's voice is so raw. "I should go deal with that."

"Yeah," And because Adora still looks so kissable and Catra is still a bit drunk, "Come back though, alright?"

"'You're saying that like I want to leave in the first place," She rests a hand on Catra's thigh again, looks up. "You are so, so pretty. Stupid drunk college students suddenly feel like torture."

And Adora is out the door before Catra can protest. She sits there for a moment, not knowing what to do, still blissed out from all the kissing. She leans back, lets her head rest against some cabinet dully. She only properly looks around the room when she hears someone walk in to fill their drinks. How long had they been kissing? Did Mara's stupid popular song playlist save the awkwardness of someone walking in on them?

She catches onto a bowl of candy next to her – because against everything, even the dumb ears, she's half-forgotten it's Halloween. She rifles through the bowl until she finds the candy she actually likes, sticks a lollipop in her mouth. It's cherry. Maybe grape. Her mind is still a bit hazy.

Adora doesn't return for long enough that Catra starts feeling antsy and left behind. She swings herself off the counter deftly and starts to move out the door. She doesn't know who she's planning to find – maybe she can panic to Glimmer about the fact

that her costume is working, maybe she can just fall against Bow on the sofa and sleep for a while. She'd like that.

She finds herself in a small corridor of Adora's apartment, away from the center of things. Some people are dancing, some people are drunkenly arranging plans to go clubbing, some people are leaning into each other tired but content. She watches as Bow and Glimmer sway in the middle of the room, the music some slow thing that has people being unserious, too. Double Trouble dips some girl from Adora's soccer team dramatically.

Adora arrives then, stepping out of the folds of people with no time to prepare. Catra leans against the wall as Adora stands opposite her. She watches Catra's lips first, eyes dark. The lollipop feels sharp in her mouth.

"You weren't in the kitchen,"

"Got bored waiting," Catra rolls the lollipop around her mouth. "You were gone for a while."

"Someone was sick, threw up everywhere. They were dressed as a nun too. Pretty weird combination visually." Adora adds, "And I didn't want to leave in the first place."

"I know you didn't," Catra responds, turns challenging. She takes the lollipop out her mouth. "But are you gonna do something about it?"

"What do you mean?"

"What do you think I mean?" Catra practically whispers.

And then Adora is pushing Catra into the room behind her. Catra falls willingly, drops the stupid lollipop onto the floor – there's no reason to protest things when Adora's hands on her are so careful, when Adora's looking at her like she can't believe she lucked out. That's a look that hasn't really changed, one that has been there from the start. Catra has not and cannot adjust to it.

They stumble into what Catra thinks must be Adora's room. There's only a small light on in the corner next to Adora's bed, and from it Catra can make out the shapes of Adora's furniture, the little pockets of herself she has scattered around the room. There's a wall filled with photos of Adora young and old, some awards she's gotten.

Catra's distracted by the fact that the room smells like Adora, smells like girl and soft mornings and everything Catra has never really been able to embody. Adora's still holding Catra's hand, watching her take in the rest of the room. She hasn't said a word of protest, hasn't tried to explain the mess of clothes on her desk chair. Maybe it's because Adora wants Catra to see her the same way that Catra wants Adora to see her – humanly messy but loveable besides.

They're standing at the end of Adora's bed, hands hanging between them. Catra's heart is beating some erratic song in her chest. Adora's watching her, blush flooding her cheeks. It seems she speaks next without intending to.

"You keep on surprising me," Adora says, quiet.

"How come?"

"You're so pretty," She says, like that explains anything at all. "Pretty in a different way everytime I see you,"

"Adora," Catra says instead of saying, pleading, *please, please be careful with my heart.*

"Is that okay?" Adora asks next, scanning Catra's expression.

"Is what okay?"

And then Adora is leaning forward, pressing a short kiss to Catra's lips. It's so undemanding, so casual, like this is something they've done before and they're not standing in the half darkness of Adora's bedroom shy to each other's wants.

“Is that?”

“Always,” Catra says. “Always.”

There’s a part of Catra whispering, but *we’re friends, but you know me* , over and over again in a refrain to maybe stop this, to stop Catra leaning forward into Adora’s space, bringing their hands to press against their sternums as she steps nearer, as she kisses Adora wholly, swallowing whatever sweet honeycombed thing is sitting in her chest. Adora guides Catra back, still kissing, never not gentle, never not delicate.

They fall onto the bed like that, Catra falling first. Adora’s bed smells just washed, all clean and nice the same way she is. Adora kisses up up up, finding Catra’s jaw, the soft of her waist and Catra presses back into it. It’s so lovely, this moment. Adora tastes sweet all over, until Catra’s pressing forward, chasing the taste and the sound Adora makes when Catra licks into her mouth.

Catra is so blissed out she can’t even find the energy to be worried, to overthink. She guesses it’s because Catra’s already entrusted Adora with her heart a thousand times over, so what’s for her body? There’s nothing uncomfortable or uncaring about the way Adora holds her. She should let herself have this.

So she does.

It’s liberating, letting Adora press soft kisses to Catra’s neck, letting her head fall back against Adora’s soft pillows. Adora kisses her deep and slow and everywhere, too. Both sides of her cheeks, like she’s saying hello and Catra’s responding with a soft sigh that only holds the reply *want you* .

Adora ends up straddling Catra’s hips, hands slowly finding themselves under Catra’s shirt. All of Catra’s insecurities have dissipated – her sometimes scrawny body feels beautiful under Adora’s hands, her stupid fear of saying or doing too much, of letting too much in too fast, seems irrelevant. Adora’s hands drag slowly under Catra’s shirt, finding the span of her ribs and

pressing down softly, like she’s trying to mould something into Catra’s skin. Catra’s hands find Adora’s thighs, a sort of comeback for the episode in the kitchen.

They kiss like that for so long that Catra’s so horrendously undone from it when Adora pulls back. She leans away to capture all of Catra like this, her raw kissed lips, her hooded eyes, the stupid ears.

“You wore those on purpose, didn’t you?” Adora asks, pressing a soft kiss to Catra’s jaw.

“Maybe,” Catra responds. “Did it work?”

“As if I don’t find you attractive however.” Adora mumbles against Catra’s throat.

Time passes like that, kissing for a while before Adora says something that makes Catra feel full with adoration, with wonder. Adora even gets Catra saying things, too, all the little things she thought she would never say out loud for fear of how her voice would sound when she said them. Things like, *your smile, I swear your smile, think you’re prettiest when you’re with me, do that again, do that again, please Adora* .

They’re confessions, really, but they don’t feel as heavy as Catra made them sound in theory. They just feel like the right thing to say. After Catra says all of this the kissing moves darker, hotter, until eventually Adora's hands travel lower, run the span of Catra's belt, coming right over the buckle.

Catra can't look up. She can't. She fears that if she took one look at Adora, eyes blown out, lips wet and red, she wouldn't be able to hold back the way she has for so long, she’d jump ten steps in the face of her senseless want. She'd let Adora unbuckle the belt and then she'd let her head fall against Adora's stupid nice smelling pillows and she'd be ruined just like that.

(Catra wants Adora that way – of course she does. But she doesn’t want it like this.)

The impossible thing is, Catra's got all the images of Adora like this memorised. Some are new from today and still far too clear, some are figments of her stupid imagination. Tattooed on her fucking eyelids when she's at night and full of want and wants to think about literally anything else.

So Catra doesn't have to look.

She knows what Adora looks like when she wants something. Knows what Adora looks like when she wants Catra. (*Knows what Adora looks like always, then* , something giddy and mean whispers against Catra's neck.)

Adora's grip on her belt is light, barely there. Catra worries that if she catches Adora's wrist too hard, letting her hand guide Adora's until it's floating just over the slow of Catra's stomach, Adora would evaporate into thin air. Catra would wake up ashamed, would realise her mind had betrayed her again. For the thousandth but definitely not last time.

So Catra grabs Adora's wrist. And against everything, against knowing herself and the patterns of what it means to be wanted by Adora, she looks up.

“What are we doing?” She asks, and she hates how scared her voice sounds, how unsure.

And it’s the worst type of question too – it breaks their little bubble, breaks Adora’s dark eyes. She abruptly sits back, tilts her head, almost hurt. Catra sits up against Adora’s headboard, moves away a mirror of Adora, too afraid that if she stayed lying down she’d swallow the next words in favour of letting Adora kiss easy into her mouth.

“Sorry, I assumed. Took it too far I get it–”

“Adora.” Catra says to shut her up. She’s resting her head on her knees. A closed book. Still, because she can’t not say it, not with Adora looking so hurt, she confesses. “Adora, I like you so much.”

Because it all really boils down to that, doesn't it? Catra wants Adora not just in hidden corners of parties, not with the security of knowing there's a few drinks they've had that can save them from careless choices. She wants Adora every way. Suddenly it feels Catra's feelings have gotten too big for short desperate moments like these. She's always been like that. She feels too much but would never admit it.

Except, it seems, now.

Adora is different like that.

"Yeah?"

"Yeah." Catra breathes, she looks at Adora across the bed through her eyelashes. Adora takes a deep breath.

"Me too," Adora responds, she smiles, sheepish. "But you already know that, I think."

"So what are we doing?" Catra asks, again, because the first time she uttered the question a dam was broken inside of her. Now all that's left is the flood. She's shaking a little. Not from the cold, or how Adora's watching her, but from the force of truth she finds in her next words. "I don't just want to kiss you now, you know? Not like this."

"I do know, yeah." Adora breathes, sums up all of Catra's concerns in a simple sentence. "But this has to be up to you. We're friends, you know? And I know you. And I love that I know you but this–" She gestures between them. "I'm not going to push."

Catra feeds off of Adora's expression, pockets the comforting feeling of Adora's hand in hers, their palms finding each other through the conversation, a sort of lifeline. And Catra thinks about being brave, about living, about Glimmer and Bow and what they've taught her. She thinks about a lot of things while also really only thinking about one thing at all – Adora.

“Well I want you,” She says, and she feels like she’s finally bitten into the messy summer ripe fruit of her heart, like she’s letting the syrup lick into her hands. “Isn’t that enough?”

And Adora’s smile of response is something Catra’s never seen before. It’s shy and blinding all at once, it makes all the odd darkness and sharp want of the room recede, until it’s just them. Catra feels like she’s holding something new between them in her scarred hands, something she hasn’t quite adjusted to the weight of yet. Maybe it’s honesty, or trust, or a thousand pretty things that Catra never trusted herself to hold on her own.

But she’s not on her own.

“Yeah,” Adora says, and Catra feels her eyes well up. “Yeah, that’s plenty.”

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And now, this.

Adora and Catra at the door again. This time Catra is the one saying goodbye. Or at least she’s trying to, stealing kisses from Adora every time she thinks about stepping away, resting her hands on Adora’s hips as Adora speaks about nothing important at all.

They’ve had all their important conversations for now, anyway.

(“My girlfriend,” Adora said, this time with Catra straddling her. Catra pulled a face, watched Adora from above. She blushed a fierce, confused, red. “I can say that, right?”

Catra smiled, fiddled with Adora’s bracelet resting on her thigh.

“Didn’t we say no more stupid questions?”

“You remember that?”

“I remember everything with you,”

After that there wasn’t that much room for conversation; Adora pulling Catra down, smiling in such a serious moment like that because she’s fearless, because she likes the way Catra sounds when she kisses her. She passed that smile to Catra too, until they were both grinning like idiots, pressing confessions of their happiness into each other’s mouths.)

So here, at the door. Adora is the one wearing Catra’s costume ears now, some childish exchange that happened only moments ago. She looks cute. And because Catra can say it finally, without feeling like clamming up straight after,

“You look cute,”

“Shut up,” Adora says, smiling. She pulls Catra forward, hooks and arm around her back, hand resting just on the curve of her waist. “Why are you even leaving?”

“Entrapta said I have to watch her mice while she studies at the library,” Adora furrows a brow. Catra cringes. “I wish I was lying.”

“That’s the reason you have to leave? Really?” Adora asks. Like the first time they met, the sun is rising behind them. Dragging itself awake, pulling the earth with it, shaking off sleep as best it can. Adora’s painted golden. Catra tries not to stare, even though now she’s sort of allowed. She feels like she still has to adjust to Adora’s prettiness is glances, stealing them and trying to get used to them before she takes another, before it throws her off again.

“You know I don’t want to,” Catra says, scowling.

“Yeah, I know you don’t.” Adora responds. “I’ll see you tonight? Bow and Glimmer’s? I have no idea how we’ll break this to them.”

“They’ll notice the second I walk through the door.”

“Really?”

“Glimmer can read my face like no other,” Catra rocks their connected hands at her side.

“And what face is that, exactly?” Adora asks.

“A horrible mixture between gay panic and smitten, probably,” Catra responds, honest. Adora laughs. Catra pulls on their hands again. Adora kisses her. "I really have to go.”

“Okay,” Adora responds, then kisses her again. “Okay, okay got it. See you later.”

It takes another ten minutes for Catra to finally stumble her way down Adora’s road. When she gets to the apartment she checks the mice, and this time it’s not Glimmer who’s able to read it off of her face but instead Entrapta, who gives her an awkward high-five while out the door. She explains the statistics for relationship length. She also tells Catra that she’s happy for her. Catra high-fives her back on that one.

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“What is it with you and your freakish ability to make me look ridiculous?” Catra asks Glimmer, wincing. She doubts Glimmer will be able to hear her over the noise of the soccer game.

Glimmer turns to her wearing the same shades of red on her cheeks. She has a shirt with the symbol of a sword, their colleges’ sports logo, on the front. Catra thinks she looks like a bit of an eyesore, which only means Catra herself must look so much worse.

First off, she’s wearing Adora’s jersey. Which would’ve been fine and subtle and exactly in Catra’ comfort zone if Glimmer didn’t

proceed to draw the team colours onto Catra's cheeks, make her a massive sign with Adora's face on it that said *NUMBER 18'S MY GIRLFRIEND* that they had an argument over. (Glimmer brought it with her anyway. Catra's refused to hold it so far.)

But even with her stupid appearance, every time Adora makes so much as one move in the game, their part of the bleachers absolutely erupts. Catra shouts, Bow whistles, Glimmer makes this sort of yell that Catra thinks could end a war. Overall it's been fun. Catra's mouth hurts from smiling so hard.

Especially when Adora scores a goal and blows her a kiss from the pitch, some purposefully dramatic thing that has Catra laughing out loud, catching it in her hand jokingly. At first she tries to pull a face but then she gives up, lets her expression dissolve into something wholly embarrassing but smitten.

"Don't act like you don't love it," Glimmer responds, rolling her eyes. "Plus I can see how you're watching Adora. Maybe you don't even need the sign. Everyone can see it on your love-sick face."

And Glimmer's not wrong, exactly. When Catra goes to Adora's games – a common occurrence, now that they've been dating for a few months – she can't help but be reminded about how *hot* Adora is like this. She's rough when she plays, careful with the ball but even more careful with how she pushes other players, fights for it in a way that has her smirking a lot of the time, has Catra's mind travelling.

Their college ends up winning the state final four goals against two.

Adora scores half of them. Catra screams herself senseless, catches Adora's kiss against the roar of people. Adora finds her in the stands every single time, and every single time Catra's feels a bit stolen by it.

When the game finishes and it's announced that their college team won, Glimmer, Bow, Catra and countless others escape the

bleachers and make their way onto the pitch. The team is dancing around in some circle, Mara holding the trophy in her hands since it’s her last game as captain. Catra thinks she spots some tears on her and some of the rest of the team's faces. It’s been a really good season.

And there, between the folds of people, is Adora.

She’s already making her way to Catra, running, until they’re in the same space and Adora is picking Catra up, twirling her around in the sea of people. Everyone is celebrating around them, loud and demanding, but Catra only watches Adora. She’s shouting into the space between them *proud of you, proud of you, proud of you* , and Adora is swallowing every word whole, happiness dancing on her expression.

Catra leans down slightly, Adora still holding her up. And then Catra presses a small kiss to Adora’s forehead, so soft and so so loving. Adora lessens her grip until Catra’s standing on the ground with her, foreheads pressed together. Catra aches.

She wasn’t wrong, when she said she’d never kiss Adora halfway. But kissing her forehead, holding her hand on the tough days, arguing on the more tired ones? There’s nothing halfway about that, either. Catra has faith in herself, now, not to be scared. Not to feel like living is a tireless sprint of trying to prove herself.

Catra holds Adora’s face in her hands.

She’s got nothing to fight, battle or prove here.

Existing is enough.

*

End Notes

so many of my college aus are like 70% the main pairing and 30% friendship softness and that's like, completely understandable. i have some of the best friends in the world (you can take me to court on that) and they're the reason i am the most horrible sap. you can find them in all the soft scenes in here, they taught me what it means to care and be cared for.

thanks for reading! it means so much. also, it's tea season again so take your pick! (i recommend chamomile, as always).

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